Staying safe online in India isn't just about having a strong password anymore; it’s about being "street smart" in a digital world. With so many of us using public Wi-Fi on campus or scanning UPI codes for transactions, the risks are real.

Here’s a practical, no-nonsense checklist to keep your data and your money where they belong.

Your "Stay Safe Online" Checklist

1. **The "Pin is for Paying" Rule:** Remember, you **never** need to enter your UPI PIN to *receive* money. If someone sends you a QR code and asks you to scan it and enter your PIN to get a "refund" or "scholarship," it’s a scam. Stop immediately.
2. **Verify the UPI Name:** Before you hit 'Send' on any payment app, always double-check the name that pops up. Scammers often use names like "Electricity Dept" or "University Admin" as their display names, but the underlying ID might be something totally random.
3. **Two-Factor Everything (2FA):** Don't just rely on a password. Enable 2FA on your Instagram, WhatsApp, and Gmail. It’s that extra layer that asks for a code on your phone, making it much harder for someone in another city to break into your account.
4. **Campus Wi-Fi Caution:** University Wi-Fi is great, but it’s public. Avoid doing your banking or entering sensitive passwords while connected to the canteen or library Wi-Fi. If you must, use a trusted VPN to encrypt your connection.
5. **Audit Your App Permissions:** We all download random apps for editing photos or scanning notes. Go into your settings and see which apps have access to your contacts, microphone, or gallery. If a calculator app wants to see your photos, delete it.
6. **The "Stranger Danger" for Files:** Be wary of PDFs or APK files sent over WhatsApp or Telegram from unknown numbers promising "leaked exam papers" or "free Netflix." These often contain malware that can mirror your screen and steal your data.

7. **Lock Your SIM:** Set a SIM card PIN. If your phone gets stolen, the first thing a thief does is put your SIM in another phone to get your OTPs. A SIM PIN prevents them from accessing your network and your bank accounts.
8. **Keep it Professional on LinkedIn:** While it's great to network, don't post your phone number, home address, or your full mark sheet publicly. Scammers scrape this info to craft very convincing "job offer" calls that are actually identity theft traps.

If You Get Scammed: Act Fast

Don't be embarrassed—it happens to the best of us. The faster you report it, the better the chance of freezing the money before the criminal withdraws it.

- **Immediate Action:** Call the National Cyber Crime Helpline at **1930**.
- **Official Report:** Log your complaint at the **National Cyber Crime Portal:** cybercrime.gov.in.
- **Bank Contact:** Notify your bank immediately to block your cards or UPI ID.